

CONE

The reproductive structure of a plant consisting of a cluster of scales or bracts used for producing spores, ovules, or pollen. Cones are found on various trees, particularly pine trees.

CORM

The underground storage organ of a plant, formed from a swollen stem base.

COROLLA

Inner whorl of a flower made up of petals.

CRYPTIC (COLORATION)

Coloration and markings that make an animal hard to see against its background.

CRYSTAL

A solid that has a definite internal atomic structure, producing a characteristic external shape and certain physical and optical properties.

CYTOPLASM

The jelly-like interior of a cell. In the cells of eukaryotes it is restricted to the region around the nucleus.

DECIDUOUS

A plant that seasonally loses its leaves. For instance, many temperate plants lose their leaves in winter.

DELAYED IMPLANTATION

In mammals, a delay between the fertilization of an egg and the subsequent development of an embryo. This delay allows birth to occur when conditions, such as food availability, are favourable for raising young.

DNA (DEOXYRIBONUCLEIC ACID)

The chemical substance found in the cells of all living organisms that determines their inherited characteristics.

DICOTS (DICOTYLEDONS)

Group of flowering plants with two cotyledons (seed leaves).

DIOECIOUS

A plant that has male and female parts on different individuals.

DOMESTICATED

An animal that lives fully or partly under human control. Some such animals look identical to their counterparts in the wild, but many have been bred to produce artificial varieties not found in nature.

DORSAL FIN

The unpaired fin of a fish on the back of its body.

ECHOLOCATION

A method of sensing nearby objects by using pulses of high-frequency sound. Echoes bounce back from obstacles and other animals, allowing the sender to build up a picture of its surroundings. It is used by some bats, cave-dwelling birds, and toothed whales.

ECLIPSE PLUMAGE

In some birds, particularly waterfowl, an unobtrusive plumage adopted by the males once the breeding season is over.

ECOSYSTEM

A collection of species living in the same habitat, together with their physical surroundings.

ECTOPARASITE

An organism that lives parasitically on the surface of another organism's body. Some animal ectoparasites spend all their lives on their hosts, but many – including fleas and ticks – develop elsewhere and climb onto the host in order to feed.

ECTOTHERMIC

Having a body temperature that is dictated principally by the temperature of the surroundings. Ectothermic is also known as cold-blooded.

ELEMENT

Chemical substance that cannot be broken down into a simpler chemical form.

EMBRYO

A young animal or plant at a rudimentary stage of development.

ENDEMIC

A species native to a particular geographic area, such as an island, forest, mountain, state, or country, and which is found nowhere else.

ENDOPARASITE

An organism that lives parasitically inside the body of another organism, either feeding directly on its tissues or stealing some of its food. Endoparasites frequently have complex life cycles involving more than one host.

ENDOSKELETON

An internal skeleton, typically made of bone. Unlike an exoskeleton, this kind of skeleton can grow in step with the rest of the body.

ENDOTHERMIC

Able to maintain a constant, warm body temperature, regardless of external conditions. Also known as warm-blooded.

ENZYME

A group of substances produced by all living things that promotes a chemical process, such as photosynthesis or digestion.

EPIPHYTE

A plant or plant-like organism (such as an alga or lichen) that lives on the body of another plant without getting any nourishment from it.

EUDICOTS (EUDICOTYLEDONS)

Any one of the higher dicot flowering plant orders that together contain the majority of flowering plants.

EUKARYOTE

An organism whose cells have a nucleus. Protoctists, fungi, plants, and animals are eukaryotes.

EVAPORITE (DEPOSIT)

Sedimentary rock or mineral resulting from the evaporation of water from mineral-bearing fluids, usually sea water.

EVERGREEN

A plant that does not lose its leaves seasonally, such as a conifer.

EXTERNAL FERTILIZATION

In reproduction, a form of fertilization that takes place outside the female's body, usually in water, for example in most fish.

EXOSKELETON

An external skeleton that supports and protects an animal's body. The most complex exoskeletons, formed by arthropods, consist of rigid plates that meet at flexible joints. This kind of skeleton cannot grow, and has to be shed and replaced at periodic intervals.

FERAL

An animal that comes from domesticated stock but which has subsequently taken up life in the wild. Examples include city pigeons, cats, and horses.

FERTILIZATION

The union of an egg cell and sperm, which creates a cell capable of developing into a new organism.

FLAGELLUM (PL. FLAGELLA)

A whip-like structure of a cell used for propulsion. It is the main structure of locomotion in flagellate protoctists.

FLOWER

Reproductive structure of the largest group of seed plants, typically consisting of sepals, petals, stamens, and carpels.

FOOD CHAIN

A series of organisms, each of which is eaten by the next.

FOSSIL

Any record of past life preserved in Earth's crust. Fossils include bones, shells, footprints, excrement, and burrows.

FRUIT

A fleshy structure of a plant that develops from the ovary of the flower and contains one or more seeds. Fruits can be simple, like berries, or compound, where the fruits of separate flowers are merged. *See also* accessory fruit.

FRUITBODY

Fleshy spore-producing structure of a fungus, typically in the shape of a mushroom (agaric) or bracket.

GALL

A tumour-like growth in a plant that is induced by another organism (such as a fungus or an insect). By triggering the formation of galls, animals provide themselves with a safe hiding place and a convenient source of food.

GAMETE

A sex cell. In animals, this is either a sperm cell or an unfertilized egg cell.

GENE

The basic unit of heredity in all living things, typically a segment of DNA that provides the coded instructions for a particular protein.

GERMINATION

Developmental stage where a seed or a spore begins to grow.

GESTATION (PERIOD)

Length of time from fertilization to birth in a live-bearing animal.

GILL

In fish, amphibians, crustaceans, and molluscs, an organ used for extracting oxygen from water. Unlike lungs, gills are out-growths of the body. In fungi, gills are the blade-like spore-producing structures under the cap of agaric fungi.

GRAZER

An animal that feeds on grass or algae.

GYMNOSPERM

A seed plant that doesn't enclose its seeds in a fruit. Many gymnosperms carry their seeds on cones. *See also* angiosperm.

HERB (HERBACEOUS PLANT)

A non-woody plant, usually much shorter than shrubs or trees.

HERBIVORE

An animal that feeds on plants or algae.

HERMAPHRODITE

An organism that has both male and female sex organs.

HIBERNATION

A period of dormancy in winter. During hibernation, an animal's body processes drop to a low level to conserve energy.

HORMONE

A chemical signal produced by one part of the body that changes the behaviour of another part of the body.

HORN

In mammals, a pointed growth on the head. True horns are hollow, and are often curved.

HOST

An organism on or in which a parasite, or symbiont, feeds.

HYDROTHERMAL VEIN

Sheet-shaped mass of material altered or deposited by water heated by igneous activity in rock.

HYPHA (PL. HYPHAE)

Microscopic thread-like structure making up the body of a fungus. Many such hyphae make up a mass that is known as a mycelium.

IGNEOUS ROCK

Rock formed from erupted volcanic lava or solidified magma.

INCISOR (TOOTH)

In mammals, a flat tooth at the front of the jaw that is shaped for slicing or gnawing.

INCUBATION

In birds, the period when a parent sits on the eggs and warms them, allowing them to develop. Incubation periods range from under 14 days to several months.

INFLORESCENCE

A flower cluster or a single flower.